AGENDA
2026 Africa Health and Development Annual Research Symposium (AHDARS)
Dates: 10-11 November
Theme: **Building African-Centered Data Systems: New Models, New Power. What Can Be Done Differently?**
Overall MCs: Dorcas Odhiambo (APHRC), Judy Omumbo (SFA Foundation)

Day 1: Rethinking Data and Knowledge Systems in Africa

`Time	*Session*	*Focus*	*Speaker/Moderator*
08:00–09:00	Registration, networking and exhibition	Arrival, registration and African Innovations Village	Organizers (APHRC, GSMA, SFA Foundation)
09:00–09:45	Opening Remarks: Accelerating Africa's development through data and knowledge systems: Addressing policy gaps and unlocking cross-sector integration opportunities	Brief welcome addresses for key guests.	**15-minute opening remarks: Message of Goodwill: Hon. William Kabogo Gitau**, Kenya Ministry of Information, Communications and the Digital Economy **Opening Remarks: Selma Malik**a, Deputy African Union Chair and **Hon. Fateh Boutbig,** Pan African Parliament President
09:45–10:15	Keynote: Why Africa needs to rethink how data and knowledge are produced, governed and used	A Pan-African perspective on data and knowledge sovereignty, African scientific leadership, changing global financing, technology and the opportunity to build new models of data systems.	**H.E. Nardos Bekele-Thomas**, CEO, AUDA-NEPAD
10:15–10:45	Leadership Fireside Chat	A high-level discussion to define the symposium's objectives, pinpoint policy gaps, and discuss African agency, cross-sector	**H.E. Nardos Bekele-Thomas**, CEO, AUDA-NEPAD **Angela Wamola**, Head of Africa, GSMA

		collaboration, private-sector partnerships, and the government's role.	**Dr. Catherine Kyobutungi**, Èxecutive Director, APHRC **Prof. Tom Kariuki**, SFA Foundation CEO Moderator: **Dr. Anthony Mveyange,** APHRC Director of Synergy
Health Break, Poster Session and Exhibition			
11:15–12:00	Presentation: African population data systems for the future: The role of population cohorts	An African-owned longitudinal data infrastructure	APCC/SFA Foundation organized session Session Chair: **Jean Claude Utazirubanda,** SFA Foundation
12:00–12:50	Panel discussion 1:Who owns Africa's data? Sovereignty, power and the future of African data governance	Data ownership, governance, protection, cross-border data sharing, partnerships, and African agency.	**Immaculate Kassait**, Data Commissioner, Kenya **Dr. Agnes Gathaiya,** Country Director, Eastern Africa, Google **Hon. Fateh Boutbig**, President, Pan-African Parliament **Prof. Nicky Mulder**, Professor and Head of Computational Biology, University of Cape Town Moderator: **Dr. Evelyn Gitau**, Chief Scientific Officer, SFA Foundation
12:50–13:00	Q&A	Audience questions and comments	Moderator
Lunch, Networking, Exhibition and Poster Session			
SCIENTIFIC AND POLICY PAPER SESSIONS **3 speakers per session*			
Sessions	**Session 1**	**Session 2**	**Session 3**
14:30–15:30	Whose knowledge counts? Culture, indigenous knowledge and decolonial	From data to impact: Production, innovation	Strengthening Africa's data infrastructure:

	approaches Session Chair: **Angeline Wairegi**, APHRC	and use Session Chair: **Jean Claude Utazirubanda,** SFA Foundation	Interoperability, access and digital systems Session Chair: **Samuel Iddi**, APHRC
TEA BREAK AND BACK TO PLENARY			
16:00–16:30	Featured scientific flashtalks: African perspectives on building data systems differently	Presentations by five early career scientists (abstract winners, big ideas)	Moderator: **Dr Frederick Wekesah**
16:30–17:15	Panel discussion 2: From Digital health readiness to implementation: What will it take to scale		**Safaricom** **Dr. John Muthee**, CEO, Savannah Informatics **Irene Nafula**, Acting Managing Director, M-TIBA Kenya Moderator: **Angela Wamola**, Head of Sub-Saharan Africa, GSMA
17:15–17:30	Day 1 reflections: What needs to change?	Key messages, emerging themes and closure of day 1	**Dr. Agnes Kiragga**, Head of Data Science Program, APHRC **Kanwulia Okafor** Director, Industry Services for Africa, GSMA
Networking and Cocktail Hour			

Day 2: Building, Innovating and Using African-Centered Systems

Time	*Session*	*Focus*	*Speaker/Moderator*
08:00–09:00	Networking, African innovations village and poster session	Showcasing African data innovations and poster session.	Organizers and poster presenters
09:00–10:00	Flagship reports launch	Presentation of key findings, video summary	**Angela Wamola**, Head of Sub-Saharan Africa, GSMA **Dr. Anthony Mveyange,** APHRC Director of Synergy **Dr. Evelyn Gitau**, Science for Africa Foundation
Healthbreak, Networking, Poster Session and Exhibition			
10:00–10:30	Day 2 Keynote: The state of data science in Africa: An Africa-led agenda for strengthening the field	African researchers in data science making recommendations on how to improve data science	**Prof. Kofi Amegah**, Associate Professor of Environmental and Nutritional Epidemiology at Ghana's University of Cape Coast / or **Prof. Emile R. Chimusa**, Professor of Bioinformatics & Computational Biology at Northumbria University Newcastle. Or Catherine Kyobutungi, APHRC
10:30–11:30	**Panel discussion 3**: Private Sector: Building resilient data infrastructure for Africa's digital future	What will it take to establish accessible, sustainable, and resilient digital and data infrastructure, and by whom?	**Kate Kallot**, Founder and CEO, Amini TBC 2 MNO panelists Moderator: **Angela Wamola**, Head of Sub-Saharan Africa, GSMA
11:30–11:45	Q&A	Audience questions and comments	Moderator

11:45–12:45	African data systems showcase	Presentations/ demonstrations of APHRC, SFA Foundation and GSMA-led initiatives	Countdown 2030 Africa Mental Health Data Prize Data Science Without Borders (DSWB) SFA initiative ATLAS Umoja AI (GSMA initiative) Clinical decision support tools (Dr Jesse Gitaka) Moderator: **Dr Agnes Kiragga**
12:45–13:00	Q&A	Audience questions and comments	Moderator
Lunch, Networking, Exhibition and Poster Session			
SCIENTIFIC AND POLICY PAPER SESSIONS **3 speakers per session*			
Session and Rooming	Session 4: Room TBC	Session 5: Room TBC	Session 6: Room TBC
14:30–15:30	Inclusive data systems: Equity, communities and participation Session Chair: **Martin Mutua**, APHRC	Africa's data on Africa's terms: Governance, ownership and partnerships Session Chair: **Daniel Mwanga,** APHRC	African actors and the future of data ecosystems Session Chair: **Christian Kisutsa**, GSMA
BACK TO PLENARY: CLOSING			

15:45–16:20	Panel discussion 4: Rethinking health data sustainability and financing: A look at the post-DHS era	Funders perspectives	**Dr. Jordan Kyongo**, Gates Foundation **Dr. Benson Maina**, FCDO **Dr. Eunice Muthengi**, Director, Evidence and Learning Insights, Mastercard Foundation **Dr. Joyce Wamicwe**, · Technical Lead, Digital Health and Informatics, · Kenya Digital Health Agency Moderator: **Caxton Murira**, Program Manager, Clinical Research and Trials Community, Science for Africa Foundation.
16:20–16:45	Winners: poster session, big and pipeline ideas	Announcement of winners	**Dr. Florah Kirimi**, Head RRCS, APHRC. **Sheena Kayira, Head of** Business Development, APHRC. **Jean Claude Utazirubanda,** Co-Chair, AHDARS Scientific Committee
16:45–17:20	Closing Panel: From conversation to action: What will we do differently?	Reflections on the symposium and mapping next steps.	**Dr. Angela Wamola**, Head of Sub-Saharan Africa, GSMA **Dr. Catherine Kyobutungi**, Èxecutive Director, APHRC **Prof. Tom Kariuki**, SFA Foundation CEO Moderator: **Dr. Caroline Kabiru,** Senior Research Scientist, APHRC.
17:20–17:30	Vote of thanks	Appreciation of conference attendees	**Joseph Gichuru,** Deputy Executive Director, APHRC
`Departure			